Paul's Independent Revelation

The gospel Paul preached did not originate with man, was not handed to him by man, and was not taught in any human school. It came by direct revelation of Jesus Christ — and a transformed life only God could explain confirmed it.

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Where this study fits

Galatians · sixteen studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–5 The Ground of Liberty	**02** 1:6–10 The One True Gospel	**03** 1:11–17 Paul's Independent Revelation	**04** 1:18–2:10 Paul's Gospel Is Independent of the Judean Churches
05 2:11–21 Peter Goes Back to School	**06** 3:1–5 Under a Spell	**07** 3:6–14 Blessing or a Curse	**08** 3:15–29 The Superiority of the Promise to the Law
09 4:1–11 When I Became a Man	**10** 4:12–20 A Steel Fist in a Velvet Glove	**11** 4:21–31 Paul's Old Testament Story	**12** 5:1–12 Taking a Stand in Liberty
13 5:13–26 Walk in the Spirit	**14** 6:1–5 Brothers and Burdens	**15** 6:6–10 Sowing and Reaping	**16** 6:11–18 Teaching the Truth

Four proofs from Paul's own story

Galatians 1:11–17 · The commentary's outline

I

Paul's Claim

A divine revelation

1:11–12

II

Paul's Conduct

Before conversion

1:13–14

III

Paul's Call

To preach

1:15–16a

IV

Paul's Course

After conversion

1:16b–17

“Brethren” — 11 times in Galatians

- The believers, the people in the pew

“Accursed” — twice (vv.8–9)

- The Judaizers — never called brethren here

Where did Paul's gospel come from?

Galatians 1:11–12 · Outline I — Paul's claim

Not fabrication
"not according to man" · v.11

Not imitation
"I neither received it from man" · v.12a

Not assimilation
"nor was I taught it" · v.12b

But a revelation — v.12c
ἀποκάλυψις apokalypsis · Gen. Fem. Sg.

- A laying bare, an uncovering of what was hidden
- "through the revelation of Jesus Christ"
- Received, not achieved — straight from Jesus Himself

Any gospel from men has things attached to believing. Paul's gospel: believe, and you have eternal life — nothing added.

Paul before grace

Galatians 1:13–14 · Outline II — Paul's conduct before conversion

v.13	“my former conduct in Judaism” — a whole way of life set against grace	**ἀναστροφή** manner of life, not one act
v.13	“I persecuted the church of God beyond measure” (Acts 8:1–3)	**ἐδίωκον** Imperf. — kept pursuing
v.13	“and tried to destroy it” — to eradicate, not just hurt (Acts 26:9–11)	**ἐπόρθουν** Imperf. — a sustained campaign
v.14	“I advanced in Judaism beyond many of my contemporaries”	**προέκοπτον** a pioneer cutting a path ahead
v.14	“exceedingly zealous” — sincere, yet misdirected (Phil 3:6)	**ζηλωτής** an ardent devotee
v.14	“the traditions of my fathers” — 613 human commandments around the law	**παραδόσεων** handed down; cf. Matt 23:13

The anvil has ruined hundreds of hammers. Even Paul could not prevail against the church (Matt 16:18).

Brought forth, sent forth — for a purpose

Galatians 1:15–16a · Outline III — Paul's call to preach

God's preparation — v.15

Brought forth
ἀφορίσας Aor. Ptc.

- Set apart from his mother's womb for service
- Cf. Jer 1:5

Sent forth
χάριτος Gen. Fem. Sg.

- “called me through His grace”
- Not deserved — and neither is ours

God's purpose — v.16a

Reveal His Son
ἀποκαλύψαι Aor. Inf.

- “in me” — not only by my mouth
- “Son” stresses His deity (John 20:31)

Reach the Gentiles
ἔθνεσιν Dat. Pl. Neut.

- “that I might preach Him among the Gentiles”
- Israel's zealot sent to the nations

You don't have to like the people God sends you to. God loves them — give them the gospel, and they become your brother or sister.

Three years with the Lord

Galatians 1:16b–17 · Outline IV — Paul's course after conversion

What he did not do

- Did not confer with flesh and blood — no human being
- Did not go up to Jerusalem to the apostles

προσανεθέμην
Aor. Mid. — lay a matter before another; a deliberate choice

Damascus
Converted on the road (Acts 9)

→

Arabia
About three years — revelation from the risen Lord

→

Damascus
Ministered — then over the wall in a basket

The Twelve

- About three years with Jesus
- One speaking to twelve

Paul

- About three years in Arabia
- One-on-one with the risen Lord

Want to hear what God told Paul, in succinct form? Read Romans.

Discuss and apply

Galatians 1:11–17 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. How does Paul's former conduct — persecuting and trying to destroy the church — strengthen his testimony rather than weaken it?

2. Why did Paul deliberately avoid Jerusalem and the apostles after his conversion, going instead to Arabia?

Apply

Grace Reaches the Least Likely

Name someone you've decided is beyond reach and pray for them specifically, asking God to do for them what He did for Paul.

Called Before You Could Earn It

Thank God today for a purpose in your life that began before you could have earned it.

In one line: Paul's gospel came by revelation, not invention — and a changed life proved it.